Symptoms to Watch For

Food reactions aren't always obvious. Use this guide to know what to notice, then score it honestly.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

Digestion — bloating, gas, belching, reflux or heartburn, nausea, cramping, constipation, diarrhea or urgency, changes in your bowel movements

Joints & muscles — pain, stiffness (especially in the morning), swelling, aches, weakness

Energy & brain — fatigue, an energy crash after meals, brain fog, poor focus, trouble finding words, dizziness

Mood & sleep — anxiety, irritability, low mood, trouble falling or staying asleep, waking unrefreshed

Skin — rashes, eczema, acne, itching, hives, flushing, psoriasis flares

Head, sinus & mouth — headaches or migraines, congestion, sneezing, post-nasal drip, itchy mouth or throat, mouth sores, ringing ears

Heart & fluid — racing heart after eating, puffiness, water retention (rings or socks feel tight)

Cravings & appetite — strong cravings, never feeling full

TIMING

- Some reactions show up within minutes. Many take **24–72 hours**. That's why you score every day, not just after meals.

ADJUSTMENT SYMPTOMS IN THE FIRST WEEK

- Headaches, tiredness, irritability and cravings around Days 2–7 are usually your body coming off sugar and caffeine, not a food reaction. They typically ease by Days 7–10. Drink water with a pinch of sea salt, eat enough protein and rest.

ADD YOUR OWN CONDITION'S SYMPTOMS

- **Thyroid (Hashimoto's):** cold hands and feet, hair shedding, dry skin, puffiness
- **Rheumatoid arthritis:** minutes of morning stiffness, number of swollen joints
- **Psoriasis or eczema:** size of the flare, itch level
- **IBD or IBS:** number of bowel movements, urgency
- **Lupus:** joint pain, rash, fatigue · **MS:** fatigue, numbness or tingling

HOW TO SCORE

- **1** = no symptoms · **10** = the worst you can imagine.
- Score at the same times each day and compare against *your own* scores, not how you think you should feel.
- Write down anything unusual — a new symptom counts too.

Get medical help for blood in your stool, unexplained weight loss, or a fever. Call emergency services for swelling of the lips, tongue or throat, or trouble breathing.